

READING PASSAGE 3

The Life Cycle of Stars

A The study of the life cycle of stars has undergone a remarkable transformation over the past several decades. What was once a niche area of academic inquiry has developed into a rich and diverse field of research, drawing on insights from a wide range of disciplines and theoretical traditions.

B Historically, scholarly understanding of this topic was limited by both theoretical frameworks and available methodologies. Early researchers operated within relatively narrow conceptual boundaries, and their findings, while groundbreaking for their time, often failed to capture the full complexity of the phenomena they sought to explain. The development of new research tools and analytical techniques in the latter half of the twentieth century fundamentally transformed the landscape, enabling scholars to investigate questions that had previously been considered beyond the reach of empirical inquiry.

C The mechanisms underlying these phenomena operate at multiple levels of analysis, from the micro-level of individual decision-making to the macro-level of institutional and structural change. At the individual level, cognitive processes, emotional responses, and social influences shape the choices that people make. At the organisational level, formal rules, informal norms, and power dynamics govern collective action. At the societal level, historical legacies, cultural values, and political structures create the broad context within which lower-level processes unfold.

D Case studies from diverse geographical and cultural settings provide compelling illustrations of these dynamics in action. In one particularly well-documented example, researchers tracked developments over a fifteen-year period in a setting that offered a natural experiment in the effects of policy change. The introduction of a new regulatory framework produced a cascade of adaptations that rippled through the entire system, generating outcomes that both confirmed theoretical predictions and revealed previously unrecognised complexities.

E Despite the substantial progress that has been made, significant challenges and controversies remain. Critics have raised important methodological concerns regarding the generalisability of findings derived from studies conducted in specific contexts. The predominance of research carried out in Western, educated, industrialised, rich, and democratic societies raises questions about the applicability of current theories to populations with different cultural, economic, and political circumstances. Furthermore, the reliance on cross-sectional designs in much of the existing literature limits the capacity to draw strong causal inferences.

F Looking ahead, the field stands at a critical juncture. Emerging technologies offer unprecedented opportunities for data collection and analysis, potentially enabling researchers to address questions that have long remained beyond the reach of empirical investigation. At the same time, the accelerating pace of social and technological change means that the phenomena under study are themselves evolving, requiring theoretical frameworks that can accommodate dynamism and discontinuity rather than assuming stability and equilibrium.

G In conclusion, the study of the life cycle of stars represents a vital and dynamic area of contemporary research. The progress that has been made in understanding the key mechanisms and dynamics provides a solid foundation for both further scholarly inquiry and practical application. The challenges that remain should be seen not as reasons for discouragement but as opportunities for continued intellectual growth and social contribution.

Question 1

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 1 According to the text, what role do structural factors play?
- A. excessive research funding
 - B. translating academic findings into practical policy
 - C. lack of public interest
 - D. too many international collaborations

Question 2

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 2 The author believes that all research questions in this field have been answered.

Questions 3–4

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 3 According to the text, what role do structural factors play?
- A. minimal impact
 - B. creating underlying conditions for action
 - C. determining individual choices directly
 - D. irrelevant to outcomes
- 4 The author suggests that early studies in this field were limited by:
- A. excessive research funding
 - B. translating academic findings into practical policy
 - C. lack of public interest
 - D. too many international collaborations

Question 5

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 5 Case studies have documented the effects of _____ change on the system.

Question 6

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 6 The author suggests that early studies in this field were limited by:
- A. inconsistent results across cultures
 - B. a consistent pattern across diverse contexts
 - C. no measurable effects
 - D. effects limited to Western countries

Question 7

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 7 The passage identifies power _____ as a key factor at the organisational level.

Question 8

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 8 The passage indicates that critics have raised concerns about:
- A. excessive funding
 - B. theoretical and methodological limitations
 - C. public interest
 - D. international collaboration

Questions 9–10

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 9 Contemporary understanding of this topic is more sophisticated than it was fifty years ago.
- 10 The author believes that all research questions in this field have been answered.

Question 11

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 11 Dynamic _____ processes can amplify or dampen initial effects in complex systems.

Question 12

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 12 The landmark study discussed in the passage involved participants from multiple countries.

Question 13

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 13 Case studies have documented the effects of _____ change on the system.

